Class 10 SST - Chapter 7: Forest and Wildlife Resources

🌟 Introduction to the Chapter

India is one of the world's richest countries in terms of its vast array of biological diversity. This chapter discusses the conservation of flora and fauna, the impact of colonial policies on Indian forests, and local community efforts to protect ecological resources.

📌 Flora and Fauna in India

India has nearly 8% of the total number of species in the world (estimated to be 1.6 million). However, at least 10% of India's recorded wild flora and 20% of its mammals are on the threatened list.

Categories of Existing Plants and Animal Species (IUCN)

1. **Normal Species:** Species whose population levels are considered to be normal for their survival.
2. **Endangered Species:** Species which are in danger of extinction (e.g., Black buck, crocodile, Indian wild ass).
3. **Vulnerable Species:** Species whose population has declined to levels from where it is likely to move into the endangered category in the near future.
4. **Rare Species:** Species with a small population.
5. **Endemic Species:** Species which are only found in some particular areas usually isolated by natural or geographical barriers (e.g., Andaman teal, Nicobar pigeon).

6. **Extinct Species:** Species which are not found after searches of known or likely areas where they may occur (e.g., Asiatic cheetah, pink head duck).

⚡ Conservation of Forest and Wildlife in India

Conservation preserves the ecological diversity and our life support systems—water, air, and soil.

- **The Indian Wildlife (Protection) Act:** Implemented in 1972, with various provisions for protecting habitats. An all-India list of protected species was also published.
- **Project Tiger:** One of the most well-publicized wildlife campaigns in the world, launched in 1973 to save the tiger population from massive depletion.

Types and Distribution of Forest and Wildlife Resources

- **Reserved Forests:** More than half of the total forest land has been declared reserved forests (most valuable for conservation).
- **Protected Forests:** Almost one-third of the total forest area is protected forest, declared by the Forest Department.
- **Unclassed Forests:** Other forests and wastelands belonging to both government and private individuals.

❌ Common Mistakes to Avoid

> [!WARNING]
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> 1. **Endangered vs Extinct:** Endangered means they are close to vanishing but still exist. Extinct means they are completely gone. Don't confuse the examples!
> 2. **Project Tiger Date:** Always remember it was launched in 1973, not 1972 (which was the general Wildlife Protection Act).

📝 Quick Revision

Community and Conservation

Conservation strategies are not new in India. We often ignore that in India, forests are also home to some of the traditional communities.

- In Sariska Tiger Reserve, Rajasthan, villagers have fought against mining by citing the Wildlife Protection Act.
- The inhabitants of five villages in the Alwar district of Rajasthan have declared 1,200 hectares of forest as the *Bhairodev Dakav 'Sonchuri'*, creating their own set of rules and regulations which do not allow hunting.
- **Chipko Movement:** A famous movement in the Himalayas successfully resisted deforestation in several areas.
- **Joint Forest Management (JFM):** Originating in Odisha in 1988, JFM depends on the formation of local village institutions that undertake protection activities mostly on degraded forest land managed by the forest department.